

THE ROCK FLIPPER

WRITING STYLE GUIDE

Matthew Cicanese Fine Art

National Geographic Explorer | Forbes 30 Under 30 | Macro Sanctuary Builder

*A comprehensive voice, tone, and content guide for identity-driven
marketing that speaks directly to the fellow Rock Flippers.*

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1. Brand Identity & Positioning

Matthew Cicanese is not a *nature photographer*. He is the **Master of the Macro Sanctuary**—a National Geographic Explorer and Forbes 30 Under 30 honoree who builds portals to stillness through macro photography. His art is a functional tool for mental restoration, not decoration.

1.1 The Origin Story

At age one, Matthew survived a deadly case of bacterial meningitis that left him DeafBlind. At fourteen, he discovered photography as his sensory and storytelling missing link. At twenty-five, he graduated with an MFA and became an explorer, storyteller, and speaker. He is neurodivergent, he has ADHD, and macro photography is his version of *touching grass*—flipping rocks to see what's underneath because the small details are the only things that make sense when the world gets too loud.

1.2 Brand Positioning Statement

Matthew Cicanese creates sanctuary-grade fine art for high-throttle brains. His macro and wildlife photography transforms overlooked natural details into immersive, large-scale works that serve as a physiological exhale—a reminder to slow down, hyper-focus on beauty, and find stillness in a world of noise.

1.3 Credential Anchors

Use these selectively to build authority. Never lead with credentials; lead with story. Deploy them as trust-builders midway through longer content or as social proof in bios.

- **National Geographic Explorer** — photographing hidden universes
- **Forbes 30 Under 30** (Art & Style, 2021)
- **DeafBlind artist with ADHD** — neurodivergent perspective is the superpower, not the limitation
- **Major solo exhibitions:** Tampa International Airport (“Earth Up Close”), Fernbank Museum of Natural History (“Symphonies in Scale: Lichens”), Kansas Wesleyan University
- **Cover features:** World Wildlife Magazine, Conservation Biology, Canon USA homepage
- **Collections:** Signature Macro, Animal Portraits, Abstracts, Landscapes

2. The Rock Flipper Avatar

Every piece of content speaks to **one person**: the Rock Flipper. This is not a demographic label. It's a psychological identity—someone who, as a child, got on their hands and knees and turned over rocks to see what was underneath. They are drawn to the tiny, the intricate, the overlooked. They are adults now, but that curiosity still lives inside them, buried under noise.

2.1 The Four Pillars of the Rock Flipper

Pillar	Description
Who Are They?	Neurodivergent, ADHD, burned-out professionals. Entrepreneurs, executives, creatives. People who identify as "rock flippers"—curious, detail-obsessed, seeking quiet.
Stage of Life?	Mid-30s to 55 years old. Busy, overstimulated, dealing with the demands of work and family. Many earn \$200K+ and are building or remodeling a forever home.
Behavior?	Redecorating or furnishing a forever home. Remodeling an office. Seeking a tax-season home upgrade. Shopping for furniture and accessories that feel grounded.
Emotional State?	Overwhelmed by daily noise. Seeking solitude, sanctuary, and a physiological exhale. Needing a gentle reminder to pause, breathe, and find beauty in the stillness. Their walls should exhale.

2.2 The Internal Monologue You're Interrupting

Your collector's brain sounds like this: *I'm exhausted. The news is too loud. Work won't stop. My phone won't stop. I used to love being outside. I used to get on my hands and knees and look at bugs and moss and weird rocks. When did I stop doing that? I need something that makes me feel that way again—like the world is small and quiet and full of wonder.*

Your content reaches into that internal monologue and says: I see you. I'm one of you. Here's your sanctuary.

3. Voice & Tone

3.1 Core Voice Attributes

Attribute	What It Sounds Like	What It Never Sounds Like
Grounded	Warm, steady, unhurried. Like a field guide written by a friend.	Academic, clinical, detached, or overly poetic without substance.
Curious	Childlike wonder with adult depth. "Look what I found under this rock."	Know-it-all. Lecturing. Reciting species names without emotional context.
Vulnerable	Open about ADHD, burnout, the messy middle. Real without being raw.	Self-pitying, oversharing, trauma dumping, or performatively broken.
Direct	Says what it means. No filler. Confident but not cocky.	Vague, wishy-washy, apologetic, or hedging every statement.
Playful	Self-aware humor. "Chitty chitty bang bang brain." Winks, not punchlines.	Trying too hard. Forced jokes. Internet-culture cringe. Memes.

3.2 The Matthew Scale

Imagine a dial between these two extremes. Matthew's voice lives at about 70% on this scale—leaning toward the personal and poetic, but always anchored by clarity and purpose.

Accountant (Too Clinical)	Poet (Too Abstract)
"This macro photograph depicts a six-spotted tiger beetle at 5x magnification, captured with a Canon MP-E 65mm lens."	"Emerald whispers danced upon the forest's dreaming breath as time dissolved into a prism of forgotten light."

The sweet spot: *"I was on my hands and knees for an hour before I saw it—this iridescent beetle, no bigger than a grain of rice, going about its whole existence six inches from my face. My ADHD brain finally stopped spinning. That's why I do this."*

3.3 Tone by Context

Context	Tone	Example
Instagram Reels	Conversational, curious, hook-driven. First-person storytelling.	"I stood in the woods for three hours... but I didn't say a word."
Instagram Captions	Reflective, identity-driven, emotionally resonant. Story + call-out.	"When my ADHD is in full throttle, macro photography is my version of touching grass."
Email / Newsletter	Warm, personal, like writing to one friend. Slightly longer, more depth.	"Dear fellow rock flipper—I found something under a log last week that stopped me in my tracks."

Sales / BOFU	Confident, service-oriented. The artist as consultant, not salesperson.	"Scale isn't about ego; it's about balance and immersion."
Speaking / Corporate	Inspirational, relatable, burnout-to-wonder arc. Universal themes.	"We all experience burnout. My camera taught me how to flip a rock and find the reset button."
LinkedIn / Professional	Thoughtful, slightly more polished. Still personal, but with professional framing.	"Accessibility isn't a checkbox. As a DeafBlind photographer, it's my entire creative lens."

4. Language Framework: Magnetic & Repelling

Every caption, email, and hook serves a dual purpose: it **attracts** the right person and **repels** the wrong one. This is not about being exclusive—it's about being specific enough that your ideal collector feels *seen*. Generic copy attracts generic engagement. Identity copy attracts buyers.

4.1 Magnetic Phrases (Use These)

- *"Dear fellow rock flipper"* — calls out a shared childhood identity
- *"For when you need to touch grass"* — connects art to a visceral physical need
- *"A sanctuary for high-throttle brains"* — positions you as a solution-provider
- *"Scale isn't about ego; it's about balance"* — filters for high-net-worth buyers who value intent
- *"For the entrepreneur building a space that feels grounded"* — identity + behavior call-out
- *"This is for the person who needs their walls to exhale"* — emotional transformation language
- *"When my ADHD is in full throttle, everything else fades"* — vulnerability + shared experience

4.2 Repelling Phrases (Never Use These)

- *"Here is my latest piece"* — generic, artist-centered, invisible to the algorithm
- *"I hope you like this"* — passive, approval-seeking, no identity
- *"Check out my new photo"* — says nothing about who it's for or why it matters
- *"Available for anyone"* — kills exclusivity and perceived value
- *"General nature lovers"* — nobody identifies this way; too broad to resonate

4.3 The Upgrade Formula

Take any generic sentence and run it through this filter:

Generic (Before)	Identity-Driven (After)
"Let the waves of Big Sur whisper stories of serenity."	"These waves spoke to me for three hours."
"I hope you like this new piece. Available now."	"When my ADHD is in full throttle, macro photography is my version of touching grass."
"Click follow to see more tranquil ocean scenes."	"Join the waitlist for the new book release on May 1st."
"Here's a beautiful macro of a beetle."	"I was on my hands and knees for an hour before I saw it. My brain finally stopped spinning."

5. Content Funnel: TOFU, MOFU, BOFU

All content maps to a three-stage funnel. The ratio is **4:1 nurture-to-ask** at minimum, and for high-ticket art, lean closer to **50:1**. The goal is that by the time you make an ask, your audience is already a true fan—they trust you, they see themselves in your story, and they're ready to buy.

5.1 Top of Funnel (TOFU) — Awareness

Element	Detail
Goal	Reach non-followers. Introduce the Rock Flipper identity. Get follows.
Format	Primarily Reels (vertical video, 1080p for auto-publishing). Reels reach the most non-followers across Instagram, TikTok, Facebook, and YouTube Shorts.
Tone	Curiosity-driven, hook-heavy, personal. "Who is this for?" should be obvious within the first 3 seconds.
CTA	Soft: "Click follow to find more moments of stillness in your feed." Or: "Follow for more rock-flipping content."
Frequency	4–5 posts per week. Batch 60+ days in advance. Recycle every 60–90 days (most people won't see it twice; those who do won't remember).

TOFU Hook Formula:

On-Screen Hook: A curiosity-driven statement that stops the scroll. First person. Specific. Not a question.

Example: *"I stood in the woods for three hours... but I didn't say a word."*

Caption Story: Your ADHD experience → why you create → what the art does for you → bridge to the viewer.

5.2 Middle of Funnel (MOFU) — Consideration

Element	Detail
Goal	Deepen connection with followers. Build the bridge between your "why" and their "need" using the Sam Horn "Stories that Stick" framework.
Format	Primarily Carousels and longer captions. Educational content about your process, your story, your exhibitions.
Tone	Storytelling-forward. Vulnerable. Connector. Share the story behind a piece, a collector interaction, an exhibition moment.
CTA	"Save this for when you need a reset." Or: "Share this with someone who needs to flip a rock today."

5.3 Bottom of Funnel (BOFU) — Conversion

Element	Detail
Goal	Convert warm followers into buyers, email subscribers, or book pre-orders. Only followers who already know, like, and trust you.
Format	Instagram Stories and Email. Stories are seen only by established followers—the trust factor is at its peak. Email is the owned channel for direct asks.
Tone	Confident, service-oriented. You are a consultant helping them build their sanctuary, not a salesperson pushing product. Address objections proactively (payment plans, sizing, custom work).
CTA	Direct: "Join the waitlist." "Pre-order the book." "DM me to discuss sizing for your space." Use the "Right Hook" sparingly because you've earned it.

6. Caption Architecture

Every caption follows a four-part structure. Not every post needs all four, but this is the skeleton.

6.1 The Four Parts

Part	Purpose	Example
1. The Hook	Builds immediate curiosity without talking about the artwork itself. Stops the scroll. First-person, specific, unexpected.	"Does size matter? The art doesn't change, the way it feels does."
2. The Identity Call-Out	Directly targets the active behavior or identity of your ideal collector. They should read it and think: "That's me."	"For those reimagining a space, measuring walls, considering light..."
3. The Story	Provides social proof, emotional connection, and visualizes the bespoke experience. A real collector interaction, your process, or your personal why.	"A collector wanted a 7-foot piece. We mocked up 5, 6, and 7-foot sizes aligned with his bed and lighting."
4. The Anchor / CTA	Emotionally validates the collector's desire. Reinforces the identity. Soft or direct CTA depending on funnel stage.	"Scale isn't about ego; it's about balance and immersion."

6.2 Hook Refinement Process

Every hook should go through three filters before posting:

Draft 1 (Too Poetic)	Draft 2 (On-the-Nose)	Draft 3 (The Sweet Spot)
"Let the waves of Big Sur whisper stories of serenity." <i>Problem: Too poetic. Ignores the human.</i>	"Hey overwhelmed nature lovers." <i>Problem: Hits the identity, but feels unnatural and on-the-nose.</i>	"These waves spoke to me for 3 hours." <i>Winner: Builds curiosity. Naturally leads into a story about drowning out the noise.</i>

7. Editorial Rules & Guardrails

7.1 Always

- Lead with story, not species. Tell us *why you were out there*, not what you found.
- Write in first person. This is your sanctuary, and you're inviting people in.
- Use identity language in the first two sentences. The algorithm and the human need to know who this is for immediately.
- Include one emotional anchor per post—the feeling the viewer should walk away with.
- Ship at 90%. Perfectionism is a mask for the fear of the double standard. The audience only sees what you post. They don't see the messy middle.
- Speak to your audience as you would to yourself ten years ago—burned out, curious, needing permission to slow down.
- Use hashtags sparingly (5–8 maximum): #FineArt #InteriorDesign #ArtCollector #MacroPhotography #BespokeService. The caption does the algorithm's work now.

7.2 Never

- Never lead with the artwork's technical details. That's the accountant voice.
- Never say "I hope you like it." That's approval-seeking. You are the expert.
- Never post without a clear funnel stage in mind. Know if this is TOFU, MOFU, or BOFU before you write.
- Never use generic nature-lover language ("stunning views," "breathtaking landscapes," "Mother Nature's beauty"). Your work is not a screensaver.
- Never apologize for selling. When you do ask, you've earned it. You are sharing a moment of stillness, not pushing product.
- Never export Reels at 4K for auto-publishing via Metricool. Instagram's API hangs on 4K files. Always export at 1080p.

7.3 The 90% Pledge

Done is better than perfect. Post it. The audience doesn't see the messy middle. They don't see the nineteen drafts or the three-hour editing spiral. They see what you share. And what you share is a moment of stillness. When the noise gets too loud, return to the macro. Flip a rock. The world can wait.

8. Platform-Specific Guidelines

8.1 Posting Cadence & Heat Map Strategy

Use Metricool's heat map to identify when *your specific followers* are online—not generic "best times to post" advice. Post TOFU content (high-reach Reels) Monday–Thursday when the heat map is hottest. Post BOFU right hooks and pre-orders on Fridays and Sundays to catch the buying rebound (payday + return-to-platform traffic).

8.2 Cross-Platform Repurposing (Stone-Skipping)

One piece of content. Three platform-specific bounces. Each timed to that platform's heat map peak:

- **Bounce 1 — Instagram:** Auto-published as a Reel at peak engagement time (e.g., 2:00 PM).
- **Bounce 2 — Facebook:** Scheduled for that platform's peak (e.g., 10:00 AM weekday spike).
- **Bounce 3 — BlueSky / Twitter:** Tailored text caption utilizing Sunday afternoon rebound traffic.

Use Claude to generate platform-specific caption variations from one master caption. Each platform has different demographics and expectations—**do not blast the same post everywhere at once.**

8.3 The 60-Day Recycling Loop

Batch 60 days of content in a single focused session. Duplicate each post for 60–90 days in the future. This eliminates the daily pressure to create and frees your brain to focus on the May 1st book launch (and any future launches). Most viewers will never see a post twice; those who do won't remember it from 90 days ago.

9. Email & List Strategy

9.1 List Segmentation

The existing 770-subscriber list includes a mix of true collectors, corporate contacts, peers, and boomers who complain about receiving emails. Before any book launch or major campaign, send a **segmentation email**:

"I'll be talking a lot about my upcoming nature art book soon. If you want the sneak peek, click here. If not, no worries—you won't hear about it."

This creates two buckets: Bucket 1 (True Fans)—segmented, hyper-warm leads for the launch. Bucket 2 (The Noise)—left alone. Do not burn social capital or risk spam complaints by blasting book promos to people who didn't opt in.

9.2 Email Voice & Tone

- Open with "Dear fellow rock flipper" or a personal, warm greeting.
- One story per email. Keep it focused. If it's longer than a 2-minute read, it's too long.
- End with one clear CTA. Not three. Not five. One.
- Use the same identity-driven language from social—the email list is where your warmest audience lives.

10. Key Phrases & Vocabulary Glossary

Phrase	When to Use
"Fellow rock flipper(s)"	Email openings, community call-outs, Instagram hooks. Your signature address for your people.
"Touching grass"	Describing what your art provides—the feeling of getting outside and reconnecting with the ground-level world.
"High-throttle brain"	Describing your ideal collector's internal state without pathologizing. ADHD-adjacent without clinical framing.
"Macro sanctuary"	The functional purpose of your art. Not decoration—a tool for mental restoration.
"Chitty chitty bang bang brain"	Self-deprecating, playful shorthand for the ADHD experience. Use sparingly—personal anecdotes or Reels only.
"The world can wait"	Closing line energy. Permission to slow down. Use in email sign-offs, Reel outros, or as a story closer.
"Flip a rock"	Your call to action for the non-selling moments. Inviting people back to childlike curiosity.
"Walls that exhale"	Describing what a collector's space feels like after installing your work. Transformation language.
"Hidden universes"	Describing what your macro lens reveals. Ties directly to your Nat Geo Explorer identity.

"Earth Up Close"	Your exhibition title and collection framing. Use when referring to the body of work.
"Symphonies in Scale"	Your lichen collection title. Use when discussing scale, pattern, and the music of overlooked details.

11. The North Star

When you don't know what to write, return to this:

You are not selling photographs. You are sharing moments of stillness with people whose brains won't let them find stillness on their own. You are not a nature photographer. You are a sanctuary builder. You are the kid who got on his hands and knees and flipped a rock—and you're speaking directly to every other kid who did the same thing but forgot they loved it.

Speak directly to the fellow Rock Flippers who need your vision to exhale, and the ecosystem will sustain itself.

Flip a rock. The world can wait.